

Surya Marimuthu

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EDUCATION

University of California, Santa Cruz 2021 – 2025

B.S. in Cognitive Science, B.A. in Psychology, Minor in Education

GPA: 3.94/4.0

Senior Thesis: Moral Essentialism in Parent-Child Conversations about Prosocial and Antisocial Actions

Advisor: Maureen Callanan, PhD

HONORS AND AWARDS

Psychology Department Outstanding Researcher Award, UC Santa Cruz 2025

Psychology Department Senior Thesis Funds (\$1,000), UC Santa Cruz 2025

Dean's Honor, UC Santa Cruz 2021 – 2025

MANUSCRIPTS IN PREP/IN PRESS

Shachnai, R., **Marimuthu, S.**, West, T., Berry-Mendes, W., Leonard, J.A. (in prep) Name of paper. *Journal here*.

Marimuthu, S., (in press). Reflecting on the Struggle for Ethnic Studies. *Journal of Critical Ethnic Studies*.

PRESENTATIONS

Marimuthu, S., Popat, A.K., & Leonard, J.A. (2026, July). *Is it me or my group? Children persist less when they attribute failure to their social group*. Poster presented at the Workshop in Social Cognitive Development, Cambridge, MA.

Marimuthu, S.,* Shachnai, R.,* Reyes Umaña, L., Erthum, A., Sims, L., & Leonard, J. A., (2026, April). *Parents calibrate taking over based on task difficulty and children's competence*. Poster presented at the Cognitive Development Society 2026 Biennial Meeting, Montreal, Canada.

McHugh, S. R., **Marimuthu, S.**, & Callanan, M. A., (2025, May). *Parent-Child*

Conversations about the Apparent Motion of the Sun. Poster presented at the Society of Research in Child Development 2025 Biennial Meeting, Minneapolis, MN.

Marimuthu, S., & Callanan, M. A., (2024, June). *What is the essence of good and bad?*

Parent socialization practices and the development of moral essentialism. Poster presented at the Psi Chi UCSC Research Symposium, Santa Cruz, CA.

McHugh, S. R., **Marimuthu, S.,** & Callanan, M. A., (2024, March). *To correct or not to correct? Parents' reported approaches to children's scientifically incorrect ideas*. Poster presented at the Cognitive Development Society 2024 Biennial Meeting, Pasadena, CA.

RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

Lab Manager

June 2025 – Present

Yale University

PI: Julia Leonard, Ph.D.

- Designed and collecting pilot data on a project investigating children's use of statistical evidence to infer whether their social group caused their failure, and its effects on persistence and help-seeking behaviors.
- Ran ECG (BIOPAC) recordings on 20+ families on a study investigating whether parent physiological stress influences takeover behaviors.
- Coordinating online and in-person research and recruitment, working with the Yale University IRB, and managing lab's administrative and financial tasks.
- Mentored and supervised 14 undergraduate research assistants.
- Creating and maintaining research partnerships with preschools and museum directors.

Senior Thesis

June 2024 - June 2025

UC Santa Cruz

PI: Maureen Callanan, Ph.D.

- Ran an independent research project studying whether parents and children explain others' prosocial and antisocial behaviors in moral essentialist terms or with situational justifications.
- Found that young children essentialized prosocial behavior more often than antisocial behavior, yet children and parents attributed both prosocial and

antisocial behavior to situational factors more often than moral essentialist reasons.

- Created two children's books that depict a character either engaging in a prosocial action (sharing a toy) or antisocial action (teasing others) as the study's stimuli.
- Recruited and ran the Zoom study on 21 Indian parents and young children from Tamil language schools.

Undergraduate Research Assistant

Jan. 2023 – June 2025

University of California Santa Cruz

PI: Maureen Callanan, Ph.D.

- Collaborated in the conceptualization and designing of a dissertation that examined how families discuss science misconceptions in everyday contexts.
- Recruited and collected data on 40 parents and young children at a children's museum.
- Developed family conversation coding schemes and coded 25 hours of parent talk using Excel.
- Transcribed 150 parent-child conversations using Datavyu, Excel, and Otter.ai.
- Created Datavyu transcription manuals to train seven new research assistants on transcribing protocols.

Summer Research Assistant

June 2024 – Aug. 2024

Stanford University

PI: Hyowon Gweon, Ph.D.

- Collected data on 15 young children at a local preschool to study children's curiosity about the self.
- Performed statistical analyses and created data visualizations using RStudio to present at a talk in a lab meeting.
- Learned open science fundamentals through the process of preregistration, collaborative coding on GitHub and R Markdown, and open-source research materials on OSF.

Undergraduate Research Assistant

Oct. 2022 – Dec. 2022

UC Santa Cruz

PI: Audun Dahl, Ph.D.

- Formatted and organized 150 high school student Qualtrics surveys on academic integrity using Excel to analyze how and why students cheat in academic settings.

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

Lead Tutor/Mentor

June 2023 – Aug. 2023

Muindi Foundation

- Taught English and Math to K-5 students from low-income, at-risk, and marginalized communities at a downtown San Jose-based education nonprofit organization.
- Created specialized Math and English curricula for each student such as book reports, oral presentations, interactive math lessons, and art projects.
- Coached students on strategies to improve self-confidence, work ethic, self-care practices, and collaborative/teamwork skills.

RESEARCH SKILLS

- Fluent in coding and transcribing software: Datavyu, Excel, and Otter.ai
- Fluent in Microsoft Office and Google Suite
- Proficient in R and R Markdown
- Basic proficiency in Python
- Basic proficiency in computational modeling architecture: EPIC, EPICpy
- Basic proficiency in participant database management: REDCap, Qualtrics

AFFILIATIONS

Student Member, UCSC Psi Chi Honor Society

Jan. 2023 – June 2025